

survived the night was a company of ARVN Black Panther reconnaissance troops defending Tay Loc airfield inside the Citadel. As fighting continued through the day, General Truong commanding the First Division ordered the Black Panthers to organize a strategic retreat from the airfield and join the defense of the ARVN headquarters. However, there seemed little hope that the ARVN would be able to hold out for long.

Meanwhile, the popular uprising the communists had hoped to spark elsewhere in South Vietnam actually materialized in Hue as students, teachers, and Buddhist monks welcomed the attackers.



Storming the Citadel

Viet Cong troops storm the Citadel's Ngo Mon Gate at the start of the Tet Offensive. The Citadel contained the Tay Loc airfield and the headquarters of the ARVN Rangers, who were also known as the Black Panthers.

Reinforcements delayed

US Marines stationed at Phu Bai airbase and other spots within 10 miles (16 km) of Hue were ordered to reinforce the city, but they also came under fire, a combination of ground attacks and rocket-mortar bombardments that kept them either pinned down in the airbase or engaged in local firefights. Using a combination of armor and infantry, Marines from the First Battalion under the command of Lieutenant Colonel Marcus Gravel finally entered the city from the south. By mid-afternoon, battling sniper fire, Gravel's forces had reinforced the MACV compound.

Continuing their push, the Marines reached the south bank of the Perfume River. Crossing the main bridge, they came under heavy enemy fire and retreated to the MACV compound. As night fell on January 31, the compound was surrounded by NVA forces. There had been no reinforcements for the ARVN troops inside the Citadel.